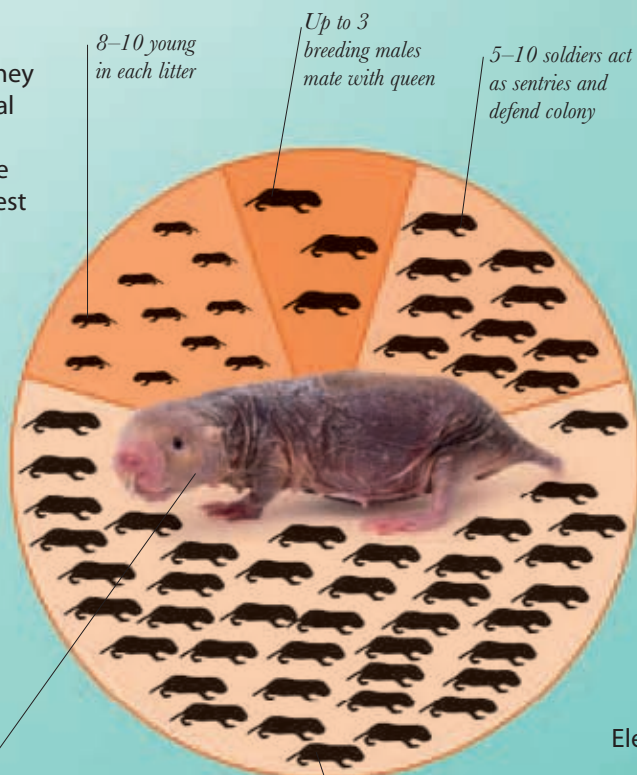


Queen for life

Naked mole rats are highly unusual mammals, because they live in large colonies, like social insects, controlled by a single breeding female known as the queen. The queen is the biggest member of each colony. She mates with up to three males and produces all of the colony's young. Some of her young take on the role of soldiers, but most become workers. The workers use their large teeth to excavate the colony's underground network of tunnels and to gnaw out food from exposed roots and tubers.

Single queen produces and suckles young



Safety in numbers

Swirling over a coral reef, a large shoal of smallmouth grunts make a confusing target for most predators. The fish form a tightly packed shoal and dart together in different directions to protect themselves against attack. Shoaling fish are often the same size, age, and coloring, which reduces their chances of standing out from the crowd.



Group memories

Elephants are legendary for having long memories—an ability that is crucial to the survival of family groups. This herd of female African elephants and their young is dominated by a large female called the matriarch, who may be more than 40 years old. She is responsible for the well-being of the entire family. She leads the herd to the best feeding grounds and remembers where to find water in times of drought. When the matriarch dies, the next-oldest female in the group takes her place.

